When Women Did Not Vote BJP: Mahila Morcha and a Prehistory to the BJP's Gender Shift

The BJP's first organised attempt at targeting women's votes can be traced to the launch of the party's Mahila Morcha (Women's Front) at its first plenary meeting in Mumbai on 28–30 December 1980. Convened by Jayawantiben Mehta, a BJP MLA from Maharashtra (later MP and minister in the Vajpayee government)[35] and inaugurated by the party's first female vice-president, Vijaya Raje Scindia, the inaugural meeting of the Mahila Morcha drew about 15,000 women in a convention that was attended by about 44,000 people in all.[36] Earlier that year, the BJP's poll manifesto for elections in Maharashtra had, for the first time, made significant promises on women-specific issues, something that had never explicitly been part of the Jan Sangh's agenda. The party promised that, if elected to power in Maharashtra, it would create a separate government department for the welfare of women and children.[37]

While its various state-level manifestos in 1980 drew heavily from the undivided Janata Party in 1977,[38] the introduction of women's issues followed in the wake of new social debates engendered by the report of the seminal Committee on the Status of Women in India. Titled *Towards Equality*, this 1974 document commissioned by the Ministry of Education and Social Welfare highlighted alarming figures on how women fared in terms of employment, political participation and health. It showed that the status of Indian women had 'not improved much since independence' despite many 'progressive social legislations and constitutional guarantees'.[39] It led to 'A Blue Print of Action Points and National Plan of Action for Women 1976', which for the first time laid the basis for gender-based programming in government ministries. The result was that India's Five Year Plan (Sixth Plan, 1980–1985) devoted a separate chapter to Women and Development—resulting in 'women being perceived as productive contributors to the national economy' in governmental planning.[40] This was also the year that the BJP launched its Mahila Morcha. The *Towards Equality* report, a 'founding text for the women's movement